

Prevocational Services

History of Prevocational Services

Prevocational (prevoc) services for people with disabilities have a long and evolving history. Traditionally, these services were designed to help people with disabilities prepare for employment by providing them with the skills and training needed to succeed in the workplace. These activities were intended to help people understand the world of work while developing essential job-related skills. Prevoc services became the framework for what is known as the “readiness model” of support.

Despite their original intentions, prevoc services have not always delivered on their promise. It is not uncommon for people with disabilities to spend long periods of time (sometimes decades) in provider-owned or operated prevocational settings without ever having moved into competitive integrated employment. This has led to the observation that for some people “pre” means “never”.

One unintended consequence of traditional prevoc services is that they have perpetuated segregated approaches and models of employment, where people with disabilities are offered existing jobs in sheltered workshops or other segregated or group settings, rather than being integrated into the mainstream workforce. This segregation may unintentionally promote the idea that people must prove they are ready for work, instead of spending time identifying a person’s ideal conditions for employment and actively matching those conditions with area employers.

SELN’s Statement on Prevocational Services

The State Employment Leadership Network (SELN) supports states to improve competitive integrated employment outcomes. SELN believes that the most effective strategies and service models to achieve those employment outcomes are those that prioritize:

- » competitive integrated employment outcomes
- » informed decision-making and community-based career exploration
- » active, individualized, person-centered job placement strategies
- » models of support that holistically consider the whole person and allow for wraparound supports for meaningful community life engagement when not working
- » individual autonomy

SELN’s Considerations for State Systems

As states continue to focus on systems change, here are action items to consider:

- » Actively prioritize services that are based on best practices
- » Prioritize individualized and active person-centered job placement
- » Invest in capacity-building efforts to help service providers adapt to new support models
- » Engage in conversations with funders about the future of prevocational services, including recommendations for changes to service names and definitions
- » Define the expected outcomes of prevocational services and how those outcomes will be achieved
- » Clearly define time limitations for prevocational services and eligibility criteria for service renewals
- » Ensure people can access employment services without needing to go through a continuum based on the readiness model
- » Ensure non-workday services support community life engagement and include expectations that adults of working age continue to explore employment

SELN Prevocational (prevoc) Visual Model

SITUATION	INPUTS	ACTIVITIES	OUTPUTS	OUTCOMES
Prevalent prevoc service characteristics	Current parts the employment system	Action Considerations for state agencies	What we hope is different because of the activity	What we hope will happen
Services have non-existent or unenforced time limitations and become long-term program centric service models When time limits are stated, they are too long and don't communicate urgency in the path to competitive integrated employment (CIE) Services typically occur in groups and/or facility-based or segregated settings There is no evidence prevoc services lead to CIE Services do not have clear and consistently defined outcomes Services are often based on legacy service delivery, not best practices for informed choice and CIE Services have not historically been monitored for wages and are often subminimum Services often present conflict of interest issues when provider organizations become employers	People with intellectual and/or developmental disabilities (IDD) Families Community Rehabilitation Providers (CRP) and CRP staff State agency policies and procedures (goals, funding, capacity building, innovation, interagency collaboration) Center for Medicare & Medicaid Services (CMS) waiver guidelines and guidance Federal laws (Workforce Innovation and Opportunity Act – WIOA, Individuals with Disabilities Education Act, Developmental Disabilities Act) Federal reports about prevoc and CIE Judicial findings (Olmstead, RI, OR, VA, UT)	Affirm that services provided to adults with IDD lead to naturally existing outcomes similar to their same age peers without IDD, including CIE Develop processes to monitor prevoc services and billable activities so they reflect best practice in informed choice and a rapid transition to job search Develop and implement clear and enforceable time limitations and enforcement mechanisms Provide resources for capacity building People with IDD, CRPs, families and case managers receive support to develop individual service plans that reflect expectations Define employment for people with IDD using WIOA definition	CRPs have business models that support rapid pathways to CIE People with IDD, CRPs, families and case managers have skills to facilitate planning for community life engagement and employment Service policies provide structure, urgency, and accountability for CIE outcomes Individual support plans emphasize clear and rapid pathways to CIE Funding structures and billing methods support high-quality delivery of billable activities that lead to CIE Time limitations and pathway benchmarks to CIE are monitored and enforced Services occur in integrated, community settings	People with IDD choose CIE and other individualized support services People with IDD have competitive and integrated jobs People with IDD are integrated in their communities People with IDD are valued the same as others in the labor market and community Youth and new service recipients immediately pursue CIE and their experiences in pre-employment transition services and transition services are used to inform CIE CMS revisits 2011 prevoc guidance to reflect learning about how services can influence employment outcomes and include additional examples highlighting best practices



State Employment Leadership Network

The SELN is a place for states to connect, collaborate, and create cross-community support regarding pressing employment-related issues at state and federal levels for individuals with developmental disabilities.

The SELN was launched in 2006 as a joint program of the National Association of State Directors of Developmental Disabilities Services and the Institute for Community Inclusion at the University of Massachusetts Boston.

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